E BLUES YOU HAPPY

The acts on the bill at this year's *Mahindra Blues Festival*

2. ERIC GALES

In 2017, the American blues-rock guitarist was a guest star for the headliners, the Supersonic Blues Machine. This time, Gales returns solo. He's got an expansive discography—which includes features with *MBF* alumni like Walter Trout, Beth Hart and Popa Chubby—but we're guessing his set will be heavy on tunes from his Grammy-nominated albums, 2022's *Crown* and 2025's *A Tribute to LKJ*, which is dedicated to his brother Little Jimmy King. There's a chance he might throw in his contributions to the soundtrack of the film *Sinners*.

3. MATT SCHOFIELD

The British blues guitarist and singer has come a long way since his initial appearance in 2011. In 2012, he was inducted into the British Blues Awards Hall of Fame, after winning Best Guitarist for the third consecutive year. Widely regarded as one of the foremost axe men from his home nation, Schofield will visit with his eponymous organ trio, with whom he will undoubtedly perform tracks from his last three albums, the most recent of which is last year's *Many Moons, Vol.1*.

4. D.K. HARRELL

Most years, *MBF* features at least one fast-rising international blues star. They've included the likes of Christone "Kingfish" Ingram and Larkin Poe. In 2026, that slot will spotlight the talents of US singer-songwriter and guitarist D.K. Harrell, whose 2023 effort *The Right Man* won Best Emerging Artist Album at the Blues Music Awards. Along with tracks from that LP and well-received follow-up, 2025's *Talkin' Heavy*, we're likely to hear him pay tribute to his idol B.B. King, with whom he is often compared.

5. ALTERED FIVE BLUES BAND

The American quintet has won fans with its punchy performances, led by frontman Jeff Taylor—whose voice is said to be reminiscent of the legendary Howlin' Wolf—and guitarist Jeff Schroedl. They'll be making their *MBF* debut, adding India to the list of the dozen-plus countries they've toured. Their set is likely to include material from the upcoming *Hammer & Chisel*.

6. BLACKSTRATBLUES

Auckland-based Indian blues-rock guitarist Blackstratblues a.k.a. Warren Mendonsa will come back to perform at the *MBF* stage named for him, the SoulStrat Saloon. He was last there for his fifth jaunt in 2018, after which he has put out two studio albums, two live compilations and a collection of ambient versions of his most popular songs, all of which will help update his festival set. ■

—Amit Gurbaxani

The festival will take place at the Mehboob Studios in Mumbai on Feb. 14 and 15. Tickets are being sold on bookmyshow.com

